Medical Spelling

Event Category: Health Science

Eligible Divisions: Secondary & Postsecondary/ Collegiate	**Round One:** 50 Q test (60 minutes)	**Digital Upload:** NO
Solo Event: 1 competitor	**Round Two:** Spelldown	

New for 2026-2027

Editorial changes have been made.

Event Summary

Medical Spelling allows HOSA members to gain knowledge and skills regarding the definitions and spelling of medical terms. This competitive event consists of two rounds: Round One is a written, multiple-choice test, and Round Two is a "spelldown" in which competitors spell terms in front of judges. This event aims to inspire members to become skilled in medical spelling.

General Event Information

General Rules	Competitors must be familiar with and adhere to the General Rules and Regulations.
Dress Code	Proper business attire or official HOSA uniform. Bonus points will be awarded for proper dress. Competitors not dressed appropriately for Round Two will not be allowed to compete.
Competitors Must Provide	• A photo ID for both rounds • Two #2 lead pencils (not mechanical) with eraser for the test. • Neon colored foam earplugs, NOT earbuds, for noise control (Rd1-optional) HOSA Conference Staff will provide equipment and supplies listed in Appendix I.
Official References	The references below are used in the development of the test questions and spelling lists: • *Taber's Cyclopedic Medical Dictionary*. Edited by Donald Venes and Clayton L. Thomas, M.D F.A. Davis Company. Latest edition. • Taber's Audio Glossary, F.A. Davis Company, Latest edition. • Purchasing the dictionary will also give HOSA members access to the audio online glossary, which can be used by Chartered Associations/ILC for competition and by competitors to practice.

ROUND ONE- Test

Test Instructions	All competitors will be given a test and test answer sheet. The written test will consist of 50 multiple-choice items in a maximum of 60 minutes. See test instructions here.
Time Remaining Announcements	There will be NO verbal announcements for time remaining during ILC testing. All ILC testing will be completed in the Testing Center, and competitors are responsible for monitoring their own time.

The expectation is that competitors read and are aware of all the content within these guidelines and associated links. Successful competitors will study all links for the detailed information.

Sample Test Questions	1. An obstructing infection in a renal pelvis or ureter (Taber's pp 1973) A. Pilonefritis **B. Pyonephrosis** C. Pilonephritis D. Pyonefrosis 2. A specialist in diseases of the nervous system (Taber's pp 1627) A. Neuralogist B. Neologist **C. Neurologist** D. Nurologist 3. The act of swallowing (Taber's pp 631) **A. Deglutition** B. Digluation C. Deglutation D. Diglutition

ROUND TWO- Spelldown

1. The top competitors from Round One will advance to Round Two. The number of advancing competitors will be determined by the scores obtained in Round One and the space and time available for Round Two. Round Two finalists will be announced on-site at ILC per the conference agenda.

2. If the competitor is more than five (5) minutes late to Round Two, the spelldown will begin without them, and they may not be allowed to compete per the GRR.

3. Based on the written test scores, Round Two competitors will be seated in ascending order (from lowest to highest test scores) for the spelldown. The spelldown begins with the competitor with the lowest test score seated in chair #1.

4. The "spelldown" term list will be arranged from easy to complex.
   Round 2, numbered 1-50, will be easy terms.
   Round 3, numbered 1-50, will be moderate terms.
   Round 4, numbered 1-50, will be complex terms.
   Round 5, numbered 1-50, will be complicated terms.

5. Round Two competitors shall spell terms in numerical order from the set word list for the given round.

6. AUDIO PRONUNCIATION OF THE WORD: At ILC, Taber's Audio Glossary will be used to pronounce each term for the competitor. Competitors can use the audio glossary listed in the Official References above to practice. Using the online glossary to pronounce each term will ensure everyone hears the same thing across all sections. Click HERE for a sample of how the words will be pronounced. The competitor may request the term be re-pronounced by the Audio Glossary or moderator a maximum of three (3) total times.

7. COMPETITOR PRONUNCIATION OF THE WORD: The competitor is to pronounce the term given to him/her and pause before starting to spell the word. This will allow the moderator and judge(s) to correct the competitor IF the term was misunderstood. If the competitor mispronounces the term, the moderator may play the audio term again and also pronounce the term for the competitor. The competitor is NOT ALLOWED to ask the judges if they pronounced the word correctly - the judges will STOP the competitor if it is pronounced incorrectly. If the judges do not stop the competitor, the competitor can assume they pronounced the word correctly.
   a. The best time for the judges and moderator to encourage the competitor to speak louder and clearer is when the competitor pronounces the word before they begin spelling. For example, it is acceptable for the judge to say, "*STOP. Please repeat your pronunciation, and speak loudly and clearly as you spell the word. We want to*

be sure we hear exactly what you are spelling." The competitor's pronunciation will not have any bearing on the qualification or elimination of any competitor.

8. DEFINE THE WORD: The competitor may also request a term definition. One judge or moderator should be designated to define the term upon request. If a competitor requests a definition, the designated judge or moderator should read the dictionary definition, or essential part of the definition, aloud to the competitor.

9. COMPETITOR SPELLING RESPONSIBILITIES:
    a. The competitor will have two (2) minutes to complete spelling the term. The competitor will be eliminated if the spelling has not been completed by the end of two (2) minutes. The time will begin with the first pronunciation by the audio glossary.
    b. No pen/pencil or paper will be allowed in the spelldown for the competitor.
    c. During the two (2) minutes and before starting to spell the word, the competitor may ask for as many as three (3) additional pronunciations from the Audio Glossary OR moderator (3 total pronunciations between audio glossary/moderator, NOT 3 pronunciations by EACH) and may ask for another definition, but the clock will be running.
    d. Once spelling has begun, there will be no other opportunity for pronunciation or definition.
    e. After starting to spell the term, the competitor will be given one (1) opportunity to change letters.
    f. If a medical term provided to the student contains a hyphen, the competitor will state "hyphen" in the word's appropriate place. If the medical term is two words, the competitor must state "space" in the appropriate place between words. If the term provided contains an apostrophe, the competitor will state "apostrophe" in the proper place in the word. Competitors will not be penalized if capitalizations are not included.
    g. A warning will be given when 30 seconds remain.
    h. The competitor **must** pronounce the term again to declare that they have finished spelling.
    i. If the competitor fails to pronounce the term before spelling or after spelling the term, they will be eliminated.
    j. The moderator will NOT give the correct spelling for a term if the competitor spells the term incorrectly.

10. Judges will write each letter as the competitor spells the term. If there are doubts about the spelling, judges will wait until after the spelling is completed and confer. If there is still confusion, the determination may be made to have the competitor respell the word or give the competitor a new word.
    a. JUDGE TIP: Be aware that sometimes there are two correct spellings for a single term. Multiple spellings will be included in the word listing the judges receive. For example:
        - orthopedic and orthopaedic
        - mammaplasty and mammoplasty
        - malacoplakia and malakoplakia
        - chakra and cakra

11. The next competitor will be given a new term to spell. If all competitors are eliminated in a single round, all competitors will return to resume the spelldown. If only one competitor spells correctly in a given round they will be determined the winner. Those eliminated will return to a spell down to determine the remaining top ten.

12. The elimination procedure changes when there are only two remaining competitors:
    a. As soon as one competitor misspells a term, the other competitor **immediately** has the opportunity to spell the same term.
    b. If the second competitor spells the term correctly, they are given a new term.
    c. If the competitor then spells the new term correctly, they shall be declared the first place Winner.
    d. However, if after correctly spelling the missed term, the competitor misspells the new term, a new round with new terms will begin with both competitors spelling in the original order.

13. Any question relating to the competition must be referred to the judges immediately. By raising their hand, the competitor will be recognized by the event personnel or judges. **The decision of the judges is final.**

14. No microphones will be used during the competition. NO OBSERVERS will be allowed during the event.

15. At the end of each round, eliminated competitors will be asked to leave the event room.
    a. OPTIONAL - At the discretion of the event management, a restroom break may be given at the end of specified rounds. At the end of each round, it may be acceptable to clap for completed competitors and then escort eliminated competitors from the room.

Final Scoring

1. If the final two spellers (or any number deemed appropriate by event staff) continue to go back and forth spelling words correctly – the following process may be used:
    a. When five minutes remain in the event, the moderator will announce the remaining time. (Each Chartered Association and ILC determines the time dedicated to the entire Medical Spelling event and aligns it with conference planning logistics.)
    b. If the final spellers are still "standing" at the end of the given time, the test scores will be used as the tiebreaker. The competitor with the highest test score will be declared the winner.
        - If test scores are the same, the competitors with the highest test scores will be identified as co-winners.
        - If this scenario takes place at a Chartered Association-level competition, the Chartered Association will most likely advance the co-winners plus the 3rd place finisher to ILC; however, the Chartered Association ultimately makes that decision on a case-by-case basis.

Spelldown Results Form - Instructions for Event Personnel *(form is on page 5)*

- Competitors for Round Two should be posted in the order they will spell, beginning with the competitor qualified for Round Two with the lowest test score. The competitor with the highest test score from Round one will spell last.
- Determine how many spellers are in Round Two, and cross out the places not needed on the Spelldown Results page. For example if you have 25 spellers, cross out numbers 26-30.
- As soon as the first competitor misspells a word, their competitor number should be written in the last row of the Spelldown Results page. (If you have 25 spellers, write the number of the first competitor to misspell a word in row #25).
- Continue to fill in the results each time a competitor misspells a word.
- The last remaining competitor's ID number (winner) will be written in row #1 on the page.
- Complete the Spelldown Results page information (competitor ID, name, school, Charter Association) at the conclusion of the event.

Final Opportunities

The HOSA Scholarship program has funding available for HOSA members who have an interest in various health careers! The application process begins January 1, 2027, and can be found here: https://hosa.org/scholarships/.

Graduating from high school or completing your postsecondary/collegiate program does not mean your HOSA journey has to end. As a HOSA member, you are eligible to become a HOSA Lifetime Alumni Member- a free and valuable opportunity to remain connected, give back, and help to shape the future of the organization. Learn more and sign up at hosa.org/alumni.

MEDICAL SPELLING
SPELLDOWN RESULTS

Final Place Results	Competitor ID	Name	School	Chartered Association
1st				
2nd				
3rd				
4				
5				
6				
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